



SAUDI ARABIA

Capital city: Riyadh**Area:** 756,981 sq miles
(1,960,582 sq km)**Population:** 24,200,000**Official language:** Arabic**Major religion:** Muslim
100%**Government:** Absolute
monarchy**Currency:** Saudi riyal**Adult literacy rate:** 78%**Life expectancy:** 73 years**People per doctor:** 588**Televisions:** 262 per 1,000
people

Many Islamic
women wear a
veil, or burqa.



SAUDI ARABIA

SAUDI ARABIA IS BY FAR the largest country in the Arabian Peninsula. Some 90 percent of this Muslim nation is covered by the hot, dry, sandy Arabian Desert, including the vast Rub'Al Khali, or Empty Quarter, in the south. There are no permanent rivers, and years may pass without any rainfall. The discovery of huge oil reserves has made Saudi Arabia extremely rich and powerful, and has enabled it to develop and improve its industry, agriculture, and standard of living.



The Ka'ba stands on the remains of an ancient shrine, which, according to the Koran (the Muslim holy book), was built by Abraham.

WOMEN'S ROLE

Women in Saudi Arabia and some other Muslim countries live restricted lives by Western standards. Many women wear traditional Muslim dress, with long robes and veils covering their heads and faces. In Saudi Arabia, women are not allowed to work with men or to drive cars, although every girl has the right to a good education.



OPEC

Saudi Arabia has the largest oil reserves in the world. Oil accounts for over 90 percent of the country's exports. Saudi Arabia is a key member of OPEC (Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries). OPEC sets guidelines for the production and export of oil, and protects the interests of its member countries.

MECCA

Mecca, the birthplace of the prophet Mohammad and the holiest city of Islam, is in the west of Saudi Arabia. Each year, more than a million pilgrims from all over the world flock to Mecca to visit the sacred Ka'ba shrine in the Great Mosque. Muslims are expected to undertake the *hajj*, or pilgrimage to Mecca, at least once in their lives.



WATERING THE LAND

Much of Saudi Arabia's land is scrubby, barren, and unsuitable for growing food. Farmers rely on irrigation to water their fields. Recent projects have been so successful that farmers can now grow melons, tomatoes, wheat, and barley in the desert.

Disk-shaped fields are created by sprinklers that rotate to water the land.

THE BEDOUIN

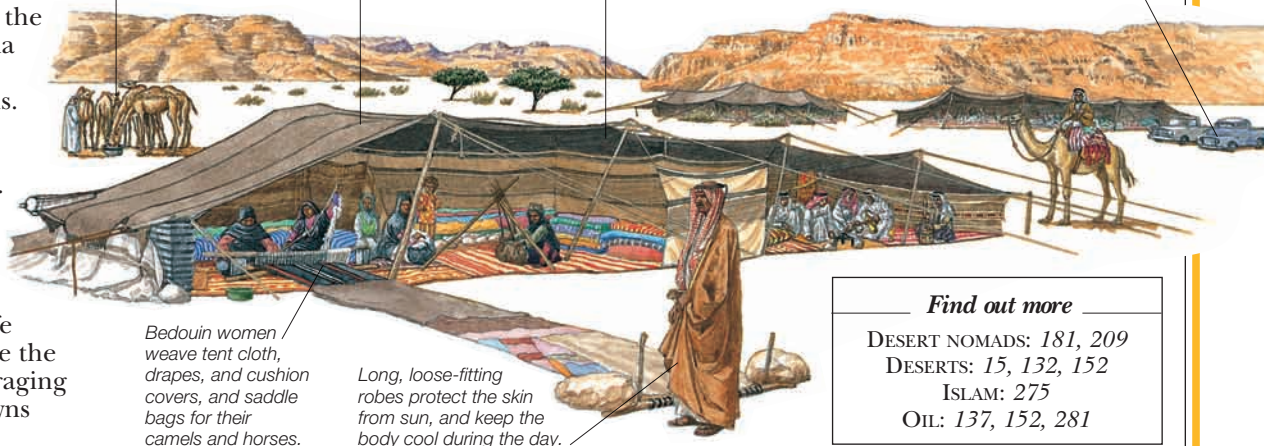
For centuries, Bedouin nomads have roamed the deserts of Saudi Arabia in search of food and water for their animals. Some Bedouin are camel herders; others keep sheep and goats. The Bedouin traditionally live in tents that are light and easy to transport. Today, their way of life is endangered because the government is encouraging people to settle in towns and cities.

Camels are ideally suited to desert life and are highly valued by the Bedouin.

A Bedouin tent is made from long strips of tightly woven goat hair.

The tent is divided into male and female quarters.

Modern Bedouin use cars and trucks for transportation as well as camels and horses.



Bedouin women weave tent cloth, drapes, and cushion covers, and saddle bags for their camels and horses.

Long, loose-fitting robes protect the skin from sun, and keep the body cool during the day.

Find out more

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